

RANJAN RAHI

PREMCHAND MAHTO, 56
JITANA DEVI, 51
Thathan Buzurg, Vaishali, Bihar

spared him the dual burden of losing both livelihood and a secure place to call home.

There was another ray of light too. Amresh Kumar, Mahto's only son, had completed his degree in English in 2023 and had begun tutoring the local children. Beyond his work at a small coaching centre, he also held classes in the verandah of their new home. In fact, he now earns more than his father used to. ■

million homes by 2029.

PMAY-G empowers beneficiaries to take charge of building their own homes, utilising locally sourced materials and designs suited to their geographical context. Each house has a minimum size of 25 sq. metres, including a dedicated area for hygienic cooking. Financial assistance ranges from Rs 1.2 lakh in the plains to Rs 1.3 lakh in the hills and the Northeast states. Through other schemes, beneficiaries also get Rs 12,000 for toilet construction, 90-95 person-days of unskilled labour under MGNREGA or the Mahatma Gandhi Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, and access to loans of up to Rs 70,000 for home improvements.

The housing scheme allows recipients to take charge of building their homes, utilising locally sourced materials

The programme has quietly scripted a transformation across the country. Bihar, for one, has built nearly 4 million such homes, achieving 98.9 per cent of its target. PMAY-G has also brought transparency to some extent. Beneficiary identification is through the 2011 Socio-Economic Census data, verified by gram sabhas. The money is transferred directly into Aadhaar-linked bank accounts.

The ripple effects of PMAY-G extend beyond housing. Survey after survey shows that it has brought security and dignity for millions; it also boosts local economies. Most of all, the initiative embodies India's commitment to ending rural deprivation and fostering inclusive development. ■